

What Is Facilitation?

1. *“Facilitation is the **process** of guiding and **enabling** agile teams to work together **effectively, fostering communication, collaboration, and decision-making** in a structured and productive manner.”*
2. Every member of the Scrum/Agile Team can facilitate.
 - a. Generally, it's the Scrum Master or the Agile Coach.
3. **Facilitation is not required in all situations.**
4. How much you facilitate would depend on the maturity of your team.
 - a. The more mature the team, **the less facilitation will be required**.
5. You measure the effect of your facilitation by looking at **how well the team achieves their goals** (Daily, Events, Sprints, Organization).

What Is NOT Facilitation?

1. Facilitation is NOT about **imposing your ideas** or **opinions** on the Scrum Team.
 - a. A facilitator should not force their own solutions or decisions onto the Scrum Team.
2. Facilitation is NOT about **dominating** the discussion.
 - a. More talking doesn't equate to better facilitation.
3. Facilitation is NOT about **controlling** or **micromanaging** the team members.
 - a. For example, a Scrum Master **should not assign work** or closely monitor every task, status updates, comments, or decisions.

The Importance Of Your Facilitation Skills

1. **Effectiveness is the key:** Developing facilitation skills is crucial because, as a Scrum Master, your primary responsibility is the effectiveness of the Scrum Team.
2. **Foundation for collaboration:** Facilitation skills enable you to create a collaborative and productive environment within the Scrum Team.
3. **Scrum is about behavior:** Scrum goes beyond just following events; it's about shaping behavior. Effective facilitation ensures that the purpose of each event is achieved.
4. **Beyond the Scrum Team:** Facilitation skills extend beyond the Scrum Team, involving communication with stakeholders and integrating Scrum practices within the organization.
5. **Conflict management:** Facilitation skills are essential for handling conflicts within the team. This includes de-escalating destructive conflicts and leveraging constructive conflicts.
6. **Problem-solving:** Scrum Teams solve problems, and a Scrum Master with strong facilitation skills can guide decision-making processes without imposing their expertise.

Active Listening

1. **Active listening** is a communication skill that involves **focusing on understanding what the speaker is saying**. It is listening on purpose. It is about putting the speaker first.
2. Active listening is a **critical facilitation skill** for Scrum Masters as it fosters **empathy, trust, and open communication**.
3. **To develop/improve your Active Listening skills:**
 - a. Be fully present in the conversation.
 - b. Practice eye contact.
 - c. Don't judge or provide unsolicited advice.
 - d. Don't interrupt the speaker.
 - e. Paraphrase key statements.
 - f. Summarize the most important points from the conversation.
 - g. Ask open-ended questions.

Facilitating The Sprint Planning Event

1. If you facilitate **Sprint Planning**, start by emphasizing what the goal of the event is.
 - a. **Reminder:** Define a Sprint Goal, select the right set of PBIs for the Sprint, and discuss/refine the PBIs so the team is confident to start working.
2. Help the team eliminate dysfunctions/problems that turn the Sprint Planning event into a long and unproductive meeting.
3. **Common problems are:**
 - a. The Product Owner (PO) does not attend the Sprint Planning event.
 - b. No use of Sprint Goals.
 - c. Unrealistic Expectations.
 - d. Lack of Preparation.
 - e. Lack of Collaboration.
4. **Do not act as a Scrum Police**, but remember that as a Scrum Master, you are accountable for establishing Scrum as defined in the Scrum Guide. The Scrum Events, Roles, Artifacts, and their Commitments are mandatory.

Facilitating The Daily Scrum Event - Part 1

1. If you facilitate Daily Scrum, make sure the developers **focus on inspecting progress toward the Sprint Goal** and making an actionable plan for the next day of work.
2. **Daily Scrum is for the Developers.** The Scrum Master is not required to attend. If you do attend, do NOT make yourself the center of attention. Your ultimate goal should be to help the developers grow to a point where no facilitation is required on your part.
3. **Common problems/dysfunctions during Daily Scrum events are:**
 - a. Developers are skipping the event.
 - i. **Solution:** Make sure the developers understand the true value of the event. And what the consequences are if they skip it (lost transparency).
 - b. Status meeting (devs reporting status to SM, PO, or stakeholders).
 - i. **Solution:** Stick to the purpose of the event.

Facilitating The Daily Scrum Event - Part 2

- c. Developers are distracted and the discussions are long (in many cases, not relevant to the purpose of the event).
 - i. **Solution:** Use the facilitation technique Parking Lot. Teach all members to respect the timebox (15 minutes max.)
- d. Not having the same place and time every day.
 - i. **Solution:** You know what to do :)
- e. Developers do not participate or pay attention.
 - i. **Solution:** [If possible] Conduct the event standing up. Use the facilitation technique - *"Talking Token"*.

Facilitating The Sprint Review Event

1. If you facilitate the Sprint Review, make sure participants understand that the event is a **working session**. Make sure the focus is on **inspecting the DONE work**, collecting feedback, and discussing future adaptations.
2. **Common problems during the Sprint Review event are:**
 - a. Stakeholders do not attend.
 - i. **Solution:** Work with the PO to identify and invite the key stakeholders. Coach the stakeholders on how important their feedback is.
 - b. Just a demo.
 - i. **Solution:** Have an agenda. Clearly state the purpose of the event. Let the stakeholders interact with the new functionality to increase engagement and collaboration.
 - c. Gate to deliver value.
 - i. **Solution:** Collaborate with stakeholders during the Sprints and do small and frequent releases. **Releasing the increment is the only way to deliver value.** Make sure the Definition of Done and Acceptance Criteria are met before the release.

Facilitating The Sprint Retrospective Event

1. If you facilitate the Sprint Retrospective event, make sure the team understands the real purpose of the event - **inspect how the last Sprint went and plan ways to increase quality and effectiveness.**
2. Common problems during the Sprint Retrospective event are:
 - a. Vague improvement goals.
 - i. **Solution:** Lead the team to identify specific action items. Consider using the structure *“Start, Stop, Continue”*
 - b. A place for complaints.
 - i. **Solution:** Understand the **root cause of the complaints**, and share with the team that there is no point complaining about factors they cannot change. **Ask questions** to lead the team to a solution-oriented discussion that identifies **Action Items**.
 - c. Stakeholders participation.
 - i. **Solution:** Coach the stakeholders that they can provide feedback, get information from the team at any time, but the event is specifically for the team.
3. The *“Start, Stop, Continue”* is an **action-oriented facilitation tool** (structure for the event) that you can use to lead your Sprint Retrospectives. The focus is on **behavioral changes** that increase effectiveness. Use voting to prioritize the action items. Bring the action items to the next Retrospective to start the discussion.